THEORY SHEET

English Tenses — Overview

Grammar & Basics — Week 7 Catch-Up (Weeks 1 & 2 material)

Present Simple vs. Present Continuous

Present Simple	Present Continuous
Use: things true in general, habits, facts *I **work** at Hogeschool Utrecht.* *Water **boils** at 100°C.* **Clue words:** every day, usually, always, often, never	**Use:** actions happening now, temporary situations *He **is getting** dressed right now.* *I **am working** at a pizza place this summer.* **Clue words:** (right) now, at the moment, this week, this summer

Side by side: *It **rains** a lot in this country.* (= general truth) vs. *It **is raining** now. Let's stay in.* (= happening right now)

Past Simple vs. Present Perfect

Past Simple — finished	Present Perfect — not finished / result now
Completed action in the past *I **lived** in Groningen for 8 years.* (= not anymore) *Shakespeare **died** in 1616.* **Clue words:** yesterday, ago, last..., in (+ past time), when...	Action from past until now, OR past action with a result you can still see *I **have lived** in Utrecht for 6 years.* (= still true) *She **has lost** her key.* (= she still doesn't have it) **Clue words:** since (+ moment), for (+ duration, still ongoing), yet, already, ever, never Note: "for" can also appear with Past Simple when the situation has ended — compare the examples above.

Key test: Is there a past time reference that closes off the event (yesterday, last year, in 2003)? → Past Simple. Does the event connect to now — through a result, an experience, or an ongoing situation? → Present Perfect.
Tricky case: *She **lost** her key, but she found it again.* (= the situation is now over, so Past Simple — even though it sounds recent)

Past Perfect & Past Continuous — Two Events in the Past

Past Perfect
had + 3rd form (past participle)
e.g. had left, had eaten

Think of the past as a timeline. When you need to "rewind" to something even earlier, use Past Perfect. It's like a flashback in a film.
*When the police arrived, the thieves **had left** the building.* (= thieves left before police came)
*He **arrived** after I **had left**.* (= I left first, then he arrived)

Past Continuous
was/were + -ing

Think of it as the background music in a scene — the longer action that was already going on when something else happened.
*While I **was having** a bath, the phone **rang**.* (bath = background, phone = interruption)
*At 5 o'clock I **was cycling** home.* (= I was in the middle of cycling)

Future Tenses — Four Ways to Talk About the Future

Form	Use	Example
will + verb	Predictions, promises, and deciding something on the spot	*I think robots **will replace** many jobs.* *[Phone ringing] I'**ll get** it!*
going to + verb	1) Plans already decided 2) Predictions based on what you can see right now	*I'**m going to buy** a new car.* (= decided) *Look at the clouds. It'**s going to rain**.* (= I can see evidence)
present continuous	Things you've already organised (booked, confirmed)	*We **are flying** to Australia tomorrow.* *I **am seeing** my dentist next Tuesday.*
present simple	Official timetables and schedules (trains, school, events)	*The train **leaves** at 15:00.* *The autumn break **starts** on October 20th.*

Watch Out! — Common Tense Mistakes by Mother Tongue

If you speak Dutch...

Using "have" when you shouldn't: Dutch says *ik heb gedaan* for the past, but English often needs Past Simple instead.
~~*I have seen him yesterday.*~~
I saw him yesterday.

"Since" vs "for": Dutch *sinds* covers both, but English distinguishes them.
~~*I live here since 5 years.*~~
I have lived here for 5 years.
I have lived here since 2021.

If you speak Spanish...

Using -ing too much: Spanish allows progressive forms with more verbs than English does. In English, some verbs (know, want, like, believe) never take -ing.
~~*I am knowing the answer.*~~
I know the answer.

"Going to" vs "will": Spanish *ir a* feels like "going to," so you might always reach for that. But English also needs "will" — for guesses and on-the-spot decisions.

If you speak Polish...

Missing "have/has": Polish doesn't use a helper word like "have," so you might leave it out.
~~*I already finish my homework.*~~
*I **have** already finished my homework.*

Which past tense? Polish uses verb endings to show whether something is done or ongoing. English uses different tenses instead. When in doubt, look for clue words (yesterday, since, while, etc.).

THEORY SHEET

Prepositions — Time, Position & Movement

Grammar & Basics — Week 7 Catch-Up (Week 5 material)

Prepositions of Time: In, On, At

Memory trick — think from big to small: in = big time periods (months, years, seasons) → **on** = specific days/dates → **at** = exact times and moments. The smaller the time, the shorter the word.

in	Months, years, seasons, parts of the day, future time spans ***in** September* • ***in** 2024* • ***in** the morning* • ***in** one year's time*
on	Days and dates ***on** Monday* • ***on** 25 December* • ***on** my birthday*
at	Specific times, mealtimes, festivals, holidays ***at** 9 o'clock* • ***at** lunch* • ***at** Christmas* • ***at** the weekend*
till / until	Up to a point in time (= until) *My wife drove **till** 7:00, then I took over.* • *We waited **until** the rain stopped.*

Exceptions to the trick: Festivals and holidays use "at" even though they last days: *at Christmas, at Easter, at the weekend*. And parts of the day use "in" (*in the morning*) — except ***at** night*, ***at** noon*, and ***at** midnight*.

Position vs. Movement

in vs. into	**In** = position (already there). **Into** = movement (going there). *I'm **in** the bathroom.* vs. *He walked **into** the bathroom.* Opposite of *into* = **out of**: *I told him to get **out of** the bathroom.*
to	Movement / direction towards a destination *We drove **to** Paris.* • *I go **to** school every day.*

Confusing Pairs

during vs. for	**During** = when (+ noun). **For** = how long (+ duration). *I fell asleep **during** the movie. I slept **for** half an hour.*
off vs. of	**Off** = away from a surface (opposite of "on"). **Of** = belonging to or part of (often Dutch *van*). *The book fell **off** the table.* • *He is the head **of** our department.*
as vs. like	**As** = job/function (the real thing). **Like** = similarity (not the real thing). *He works **as** a clown. (= he IS a clown)* • *He acted **like** a clown. (= he is NOT a clown)*
before vs. in front of	**Before** = usually time. **In front of** = position in space. *Shall we meet **before** 7:00?* • *I'll wait **in front of** the restaurant.*
in time vs. on time	**In time** = early enough. **On time** = at the scheduled time. *I was **in time** for the announcement.* • *The show started **on time**.*

Watch Out! — Common Preposition Mistakes by Mother Tongue

If you speak Dutch...

"good in" → good at:
~~*I'm not good in English.*~~
I'm not good at English.

"with the train" → by train:
~~*I go to school with the train.*~~
I go to school by train.

"behind the computer" → at:
~~*I was sitting behind the computer.*~~
I was sitting at the computer.

"since" vs "for": see Tenses theory sheet — same rule applies here as a preposition choice.

If you speak Spanish...

"en" does too much: Spanish *en* = in, on, at. English distinguishes between them.
~~*I'm en → in school.*~~ → *I'm **at** school.* (= the place)
~~*I'm en → on the classroom.*~~ → *I'm **in** the classroom.* (= inside)
~~*The book is en → in the table.*~~ → *The book is **on** the table.* (= surface)

Wrong preposition after verbs: Spanish *para/por* often translates as "for," but in English the preposition after verbs is often different.
~~*I'm good for maths.*~~ → *I'm good **at** maths.*

If you speak Polish...

Forgetting the preposition: Polish changes the word ending instead of adding a small word. In English, you need to add the preposition.
~~*I go school every day.*~~
*I go **to** school every day.*

"na" ≠ "on": Polish *na* sometimes = "at" or "in" in English.
~~*I'm on the university.*~~
I'm at the university.

EXERCISES

Part A — Tenses

Grammar & Basics — Week 7

Exercise 1 — Present Simple vs. Present Continuous

Fill in the correct form of the verb in brackets. Use context and clue words to decide which tense to use.

1. John _____ (PLAY) football at the moment.
2. We often _____ (TAKE) tests at our school.
3. I _____ (TALK) to my teacher right now.
4. Every Monday, Sally _____ (DRIVE) her kids to football practice.
5. Usually, I _____ (WORK) as a secretary at ABT, but this summer I _____ (STUDY) French at a language school in Paris.
6. Don't forget to take your umbrella. It _____ (RAIN).
7. What _____ (she / THINK) of this situation?

Exercise 2 — Past Simple vs. Present Perfect

Choose the correct form. Ask yourself: does this sentence refer to a specific finished time in the past, or does it connect to the present?

1. Peter **played / has played** football yesterday.
2. They **cleaned / have cleaned** the car. It looks new again.
3. They **bought / have bought** the car in 2011.
4. Last year we **went / have gone** to Italy.
5. I haven't seen Paul since I **arrived / have arrived**.
6. I **never visited / have never visited** Greece.
7. I **saw / have seen** my friend two days ago.
8. I **lost / have lost** my key, so I can't open the door.

Exercise 3 — Mixed Past Tenses Story

Fill in the correct past tense form. Use past simple for completed actions, past continuous for actions in progress, and past perfect for actions that happened before another past action.

Example: She was sitting (SIT) at her desk when the alarm rang (RING).
→ *was sitting* = longer background action (past continuous) / *rang* = shorter interruption (past simple)

1. I _____ (WATCH) a cookery programme on TV when I _____ (REALIZE) how hungry I was.
2. That was because I _____ (not / EAT) anything since lunch.
3. I _____ (GO) into the kitchen, _____ (OPEN) the fridge and _____ (CHECK) what was inside.
4. While I _____ (LOOK) for something good, my stomach _____ (GROWL).
5. I _____ (CRAVE) the leftovers from yesterday, but somebody _____ (TAKE) them.
6. I _____ (SETTLE) for some fruit, but as I _____ (EAT) it, I _____ (SEE) the leftovers in the trash.
7. My brother _____ (COME) in and _____ (CONFESS) he _____ (THROW) them away.

Exercise 4 — All Tenses Mixed

Fill in the correct tense. This paragraph uses present, past, and future — use context clues to decide.

How to decide: Read the whole sentence. Find time signals. Ask: is this a habit? happening now? a completed result? an arrangement? a prediction?
Example: "Tomorrow she is flying (FLY) to Berlin." → Time signal: *tomorrow* + arrangement already made → present continuous for future.

Next month I _____ (MOVE) to a new flat and I _____ (ALREADY / BUY) the furniture. I can't wait! Let me tell you more about the flat: there are two big rooms, a kitchenette and a small bathroom. Last weekend I _____ (GET) a very nice lamp for the living room, but unfortunately I _____ (BREAK) it when I _____ (CLEAN) the flat. Luckily it _____ (not / COST) much, I _____ (PROBABLY / BUY) another one next Saturday.

By the way, I have some news: while I _____ (LOOK) for the flat, I _____ (MEET) a very nice estate agent: his name is Jamie. We _____ (BE) out for dinner twice and tomorrow we _____ (HAVE) lunch together. He _____ (WORK) near here.

Now I _____ (WAIT) for my sister. We _____ (GO) to a party together later and I _____ (not / KNOW) what to wear.

Exercise 5 — Questions & Negatives

*Each sentence is marked **Question** or **Negative**. Rewrite it in that form. Use do/does/did only when there is no helping verb (is, are, was, will, can, have, etc.).*

Examples:
"They arrived early." → **Negative:** They didn't arrive early. (no helping verb → add *did*)
"She is leaving." → **Negative:** She isn't leaving. (has helping verb → no *did*)
"Somebody ate my lunch." → **Question (subject):** Who ate my lunch? (no *did* — "who" replaces the subject)

1. She plays tennis on Saturdays. → **Question:**

_____

2. They went to the cinema last night. → **Negative:**

_____

3. He is working at the moment. → **Question:**

_____

4. She has visited Paris three times. → **Negative:**

_____

5. The children like chocolate. → **Question:**

_____

6. He called you yesterday. → **Question (with "who" as subject):**

_____

7. You can speak French. → **Negative:**

_____

8. Somebody broke the window. → **Question (with "who" as subject):**

_____

Exercise 6 — Subject-Verb Agreement

Choose the correct verb form. Think: is the subject singular or plural? Watch out for tricky cases.

1. The police **has / have** the right to search people.
2. Mathematics **gives / give** me headaches.
3. Those trousers **makes / make** you look great.
4. The Netherlands **has / have** two neighbouring countries.
5. A number of people **is / are** already there.
6. Ten miles **is / are** too far to walk.
7. Our family **is / are** unable to plan a holiday. (UK English)
8. Water **flows / flow** through the pipes.

SPEAKING ACTIVITY

Find Someone at Your Table Who...

Grammar & Basics — Week 7

Instructions: *Look at each box.* ***Write a question in the correct tense****, then ask your classmates. Find someone who matches and write down what they told you.*

3+ countries visited (lifetime total) **Your question:** _____ What did they say? _____	Fun plans for this weekend **Your question:** _____ What did they say? _____	Late-night studying (last night) **Your question:** _____ What did they say? _____
Currently watching, reading, or listening to something they'd recommend **Your question:** _____ What did they say? _____	Has eaten something unusual or unexpected this week **Your question:** _____ What did they say? _____	Was watching a series at 8pm last night (which one?) **Your question:** _____ What did they say? _____
Has a very specific plan for five years from now **Your question:** _____ What did they say? _____	Another language before English (prior learning) **Your question:** _____ What did they say? _____	Daily habit: walks or cycles to school **Your question:** _____ What did they say? _____

EXERCISES

Part B — Prepositions

Grammar & Basics — Week 7

Exercise 7 — Spot and Correct the Preposition Error

Each sentence contains one preposition error. Find the error and rewrite the full sentence correctly. The fix might be replacing a preposition, or removing one that shouldn't be there.

1. She is engaged with David.

_____

2. She entered into the room.

_____

3. He is intelligent, but he lacks of experience.

_____

4. On October, we went for a skiing vacation in Switzerland.

_____

5. Every summer I fly to Brazil and sit in the beach.

_____

6. He told to me that he liked it.

_____

Exercise 8 — Confusing Pairs

Fill in the correct preposition. Choose from the pair given in brackets.

1. She listened to podcasts _____ her commute. She listened _____ about twenty minutes. (during / for)

2. I'm _____ the bathroom. Don't walk _____ the bathroom without knocking! (in / into)

3. She works _____ a nurse at the hospital. Her brother looks _____ a doctor, but he's actually a musician. (as / like)

4. Shall we meet _____ 7:00? I'll be waiting _____ the restaurant. (before / in front of)

5. The show started right _____ time. We almost didn't arrive _____ time. (on time / in time)

6. I'm so bad _____ organizing my day. I go to school _____ train. (at / by)

Exercise 9 — Gap-Fill Paragraph

Fill in the correct preposition in each gap. There is no word bank — use the theory sheet if needed.

1. _____ 10 o'clock PM, _____ the latest, I will have handed in my essay.
2. _____ one year's time, I will be receiving my diploma!
3. I arrived so early that the main doors weren't even open yet. So I just stood there _____ the building until I was allowed in. _____ a moment I considered walking _____ the building to the back door. But _____ course, I knew it would be locked as well.
4. I'm so bad _____ organizing my day. I hardly even wake up _____ time to eat a proper breakfast. But then again, I have noticed that my 9:00 lecture never seems to start _____ time. My professor is usually five minutes late. I hear she's been doing this _____ many years. I probably arrive _____ school even before she does! Well maybe not, but I'm certainly _____ the classroom, _____ my desk, first. _____ least, most _____ the time.

PAIR ACTIVITY

Spot the Preposition Errors

Grammar & Basics — Week 7

*The email below was written by a fictional international student. It contains **12 preposition errors** — mistakes typical for Dutch, Spanish, and Polish speakers of English.*
Step 1: *Work in pairs. Underline each preposition error and write the correction above it.*
Step 2: *When you finish, compare with another pair and discuss any differences.*

EMAIL FROM "ALEX" TO A FRIEND

Hi Sam,

How are you? I'm writing to tell you about my new life on university. I moved in Utrecht in September and I've been here since almost six months now. I'm not very good in organising my schedule yet, so I often arrive late. Last week I showed up to the wrong classroom twice — embarrassing!

Every morning I go with the bus to school. The bus stop is right before my flat, so that's convenient. The ride takes about 20 minutes, and during the ride I usually listen to music.

Yesterday I was sitting behind the computer working on an essay when my flatmate walked in my room without knocking. He told to me that there was a package for me downstairs. I ran down the stairs in my socks and found it in the doorstep — it was a birthday present of my parents! (My birthday was two weeks ago, but better late than never.)

I hope you can visit me soon. I look forward on hearing from you!
Alex

Write your corrections

List the 12 errors and their corrections below.

1. _____ → _____
2. _____ → _____
3. _____ → _____
4. _____ → _____
5. _____ → _____
6. _____ → _____
7. _____ → _____
8. _____ → _____
9. _____ → _____
10. _____ → _____
11. _____ → _____
12. _____ → _____

ANSWER KEY

Week 7 — Tenses & Prepositions

Exercise 1 — Present Simple vs. Continuous

1. is playing
2. take
3. am talking
4. drives
5. work • am studying (two blanks)
6. is raining
7. does she think

Exercise 2 — Past Simple vs. Present Perfect

1. played (yesterday)
2. have cleaned (result now)
3. bought (in 2011)
4. went (last year)
5. arrived (the arriving is a single finished event)
6. have never visited (still true)
7. saw (two days ago)
8. have lost (result now)

Exercise 3 — Mixed Past Tenses (• separates blanks)

1. was watching • realized
2. had not eaten
3. went • opened • checked
4. was looking • growled (or: was growling)
5. was craving (or: craved) • had taken
6. settled • was eating • saw
7. came • confessed • had thrown

Exercise 4 — All Tenses Mixed (in order of blanks)

1. am moving (or: am going to move)
2. have already bought
3. got 4. broke 5. was cleaning
6. didn't cost 7. will probably buy
8. was looking 9. met
10. have been 11. are having 12. works
13. am waiting 14. are going 15. don't know

Exercise 5 — Questions & Negatives

1. Does she play tennis on Saturdays?
2. They didn't go to the cinema last night.
3. Is he working at the moment?
4. She hasn't visited Paris three times.
5. Do the children like chocolate?
6. Who called you yesterday? (no "did")
7. You can't speak French. / You cannot speak French.
8. Who broke the window? (no "did")

Exercise 6 — Subject-Verb Agreement

1. have (police = always plural)
2. gives (-ics subject = singular verb)
3. make (two-part item = plural)
4. has (country name = singular)
5. are ("a number of" = plural)
6. is (measurement = singular)
7. are (UK: family = plural; US: "is" also correct)
8. flows (uncountable = singular)

Exercise 7 — Correct the Preposition

1. She is engaged **to** David.
2. She entered the room. (no preposition)
3. ...he lacks experience. (no preposition)
4. **In** October, we went...
5. ...sit **on** the beach. (also: **at**)
6. He told me... (no "to")

Exercise 8 — Confusing Pairs (first blank • second blank)

1. during • for
2. in • into
3. as • like
4. before • in front of
5. on time • in time
6. at • by

Exercise 9 — Gap-Fill Paragraph (by sentence)

Sentence 1: **By** ... **at** the latest
Sentence 2: **In** one year's time
Sentence 3: **in front of** • **For** • **around** • **of**
Sentence 4 (first half): **at** • **in** time • **on** time • **for**
Sentence 4 (second half): **at** • **in** • **at** • **At** • **of**

Spot the Errors — Email (12 errors)

1. **on** university → **at** university
2. moved **in** Utrecht → moved **to** Utrecht
3. **since** almost six months → **for** almost six months
4. good **in** organising → good **at** organising
5. go **with** the bus → go **by** bus
6. right **before** my flat → right **in front of** my flat
7. **behind** the computer → **at** the computer
8. walked **in** my room → walked **into** my room
9. told **to** me → told me (no "to")
10. **in** the doorstep → **on** the doorstep
11. present **of** my parents → present **from** my parents
12. look forward **on** → look forward **to**